

Draft Design:

Project Car

By Austin Solache

Brainstorm

It's difficult to search for a used vehicle these days. Either the seller is being dishonest, or the buyer is choosing the wrong vehicle for them. I propose a website that helps buyers research the car they are looking to purchase. This website can help a buyer purchase a vehicle that can fit their need perfectly. Whether the buyer wants a sporty project car to an off-road SUV that is great for a weekend camping trip.

My first idea was to create a phone app design to search for vehicles instead of a website. After considering the amount of information needed to make the right purchase of a vehicle, a phone screen would not work. I also thought of making the website dedicated to project cars for sportier cars, but after looking for a vehicle myself. I found myself looking at multiple sites just to decide on a make and model for me. So I decided to focus on making a one-stop website to focus on reliability, practicality, and advice on how to identify issues with that used car. After all the brainstorming, I am happy with the final design.

Identify

Many of the ideas I had for the project were valuable in their own way. The most valuable idea was advising on purchasing a used vehicle. This advice can save buyers thousands or even more, depending on their budget. My solution changed when I put my focus on helping buyers purchase/build a fast and cool car, to helping them save time and money purchasing a vehicle that fits their needs.

Define

The Project plan is to create a design for each page of the website. The website would consist of four main webpage layouts. First, there would be the homepage with a search bar in the center of the page. Next is the search results page that comes after searching for a vehicle. The third will be an about me page with a summary of me and my goals for this project. Finally, the last web page will be when the vehicle is selected, and this webpage will focus on one vehicle, giving out information like the type of vehicle, prices, and common issues to look out for when purchasing.

The project brief wasn't followed closely due to changing ideas and concepts. The timeline stayed the same because the same number of webpages were needed for this newly designed concept. The layout went well, and everything fell into place once I established a color scheme.

Ideate

I only have one sketch for my planning. I only had one sketch board because the meat of the project was how and what information was given to the user. So a simple design was necessary to achieve that goal. I followed the sketch almost the same way. The only changes were the spacing of the elements in the HTML. I took some feedback on how some of the information about the vehicles can be displayed. One advice I took was adding a navigation bar at the top of the screen. I added that nav bar to the site with links to the different pages of the site.

Prototype

My progress started slowly with the first page of the site. Once I got the first landing page down, the others came along smoothly with some obstacles. There weren't many different versions of the project. The color scheme had many different versions throughout the project. I started with a black background with yellow and red accents. I then took some time to look at examples of color schemes and chose soft blues and an off white background that was easier on the eyes. The car details changed a little with how some of the information was displayed. I took the common issues sections and made them into a bullet list with extra information under each bullet. One obstacle I had with the project was deciding on the color scheme. As stated previously, I had changed the color scheme many times before choosing the final scheme.

Test

I did not present my final draft to my peers. I did get a target audience of friends and family for feedback. I did this during the building stage and the final design. The main feedback I got was about the color scheme, especially during the beginning stages. I also took feedback on grammar and my word choice to sound more professional on my about us page. The spacing of certain elements on the page was also mentioned in some feedback, like the car search results.

Refine

Based on the feedback from my target audience, I made changes to my grammar and word choice in my About Me page. Instead of using “Us” and “the site,” I started to use my name and “I” in my sentences. This gave the About Me page personality and reinforced that I created this project. I also wanted this page to create a personal connection with the users. I also wanted the user to know that I believe in this project and its attempt to accomplish.

Implementation

Overall, I am proud of the progress I made with the project. I focused on the design and layout of the site, and I think it looks great. The general idea and placement of elements went well for me during building. I think the color scheme could be better and could use some tweaking. I also think more images of the vehicles and their aftermarket parts could be useful to the user.

I learned many things about myself doing this project. I learned that I need to work on my color theory and color scheme designs. I also learned that I am getting better at using CSS and HTML, which is exciting for me. As a project manager, I learned that plans change and deadlines will sometimes be late for many reasons, some out of your control. It's best not to dwell on it and pivot into corrective action. Afterward, taking proactive action is also necessary to reduce delays again. I am glad that I chose this as my senior project. It is something I am passionate about as a car enthusiast and developer.

I will continue building this project and add the code to make this site functional. I believe in the benefits of this site for people who want to avoid debt or learn about vehicles. I will continue to grow alongside this project as I continue my career.